NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 6 2 ♥ A Q ♦ 5 4 ♣ K Q J 9 7 2	
♠ J 10 8 4 ♥ K 7 5 3 ♦ J 10 9 3 ♣ 8	N W E S	♠ Q 9 5 ♥ 10 9 8 4 2 ♦ K 8 ♣ 10 5 4
	♠ A 7 3 ♥ J 6 ♦ A Q 7 6 2 ♣ A 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	4♣
Pass	6♣		
All Pass			

6♣ by North
Lead: ♥10

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

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Partner says 4♣;

With partner agreeing ♣s, one possibility would be for you to cue-bid your ♥A. Another would be just to bid 6♣. You choose the second approach.

North plays 6♣. East leads the ♥10. West plays low and you win the ♥Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Your best chance at another winner is the ♦ suit. East MAY have both the ♦ K Q, if not you will have to establish the suit.

At trick 2 pull just one round of trumps with the ♣K. Then play a small ♦, finessing the ♦J when East plays low. West takes the ♦Q and returns the ♠J.

Go up with your ♠K, you may need the entry to dummy later. Pull one more trump with the ♣Q, then play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. Ruff a ♦ with a high trump, East discarding.

Enter dummy with the ♣A, pulling East's last trump as you do, and ruff one more ♦, establishing the fifth ♦. Enter dummy with the ♠A and discard your losing ♠ on the good ♦.

It is important to be careful with entries to the hand where you are trying to establish a suit.

If the suit splits evenly perhaps you can be a little sloppy and still get by.

But in cases like this one, with a 4-2 split, you cannot afford to waste an entry too early.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 7 4 3 ♥ Q 10 9 4 ♦ J 10 ♣ K 10 7	
♠ 6 ♥ A 7 5 3 2 ♦ 7 6 4 2 ♣ 8 5 4	N W E S	♠ A 10 5 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ A K 3 ♣ A 9 6 2
	♠ Q J 9 8 ♥ K J ♦ Q 9 8 5 ♣ Q J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	
All Pass			

2♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

This situation comes up a lot. You don't have enough points to advance partner's 1NT opening, but you have a "long suit" that might play better than notrump. If "long suit" is 6 ♥s or 6 ♠s then pretty clearly you should transfer partner to that suit and then pass. But with only 5 of the Major it is tougher to say that 1NT would be an inferior contract. Here's a suggestion - with fewer than 9 points and a 5-card Major, transfer to that suit when you have a singleton or void, otherwise pass 1NT. So here you bid 2♦ and partner says 2♥.

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Of course you pass, that was the whole point of the transfer.

The contract would be 2♥ played by West.

East plays 2♥. South leads the ♠Q, North playing the ♠7.

We will all agree that you win the first trick with your ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2/3/? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = lots

In suit contracts it is usual to count losers. Sometimes in low level suit contracts it makes things clearer if you count winners. Here you have 4 high card winners in your hand plus the Ace of trumps in dummy.

Your plan will therefore be to make as many of dummy's small trumps as you can.

At trick 2 ruff a ♠ in dummy. Pull one trump with the ♥A. Play a ♣ back to your ♣A and ruff another ♠.

Got the idea? Play a ♦ to your ♦K and ruff your last ♠ in dummy. Then play the ♦A. If you've been counting you have taken the first 8 tricks. A good thing, too, because you aren't going to take any more.

In most suit contracts it is good to pull trumps early.

Here is an example of when that principle is **NOT** correct; when you need to get several ruffs with small trumps.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 7 4 ♥ J 9 6 ♦ 6 2 ♣ 7 5 3 2	
♠ 8 5 ♥ 10 4 2 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ Q 10 9 4	N W E S	♠ Q 6 2 ♥ 8 7 3 ♦ K 9 7 4 3 ♣ K J
	♠ K 10 9 3 ♥ A K Q 5 ♦ A 8 ♣ A 8 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	3NT	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♦Q

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with 4 cards in both Majors you respond 3♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner would not use Stayman unless he held a 4-card Major suit himself. Since he didn't like your ♥s it follows that he must have 4 ♠s.

So you correct the 3NT contract to 4♠.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦Q.

If you had left it in 3NT you'd have 8 top tricks and a ♠ finesse for 9.

But you're in 4♠.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 4

If you can guess the ♠Q your problems are over. But just in case you dislike those 50% guesses, try to find a better Plan.

Another possibility is that a defender holds either a singleton or doubleton ♠Q so you can pick up the suit by leading ♠ A K. This is smaller than a 50% chance.

But there is more to the odds than that. Suppose you try the second possibility and play off both the ♠A and ♠K but the ♠Q does **NOT** drop. You are still not dead! You just leave the ♠Q out there and start on ♥s. As long as the defender who holds the ♠Q has at least 3 ♥s he will be unable to ruff until after you have discarded dummy's ♦ loser.

The extra chance makes this Plan your best hope.

You could have made the contract easily by playing East for the ♠Q.

You could have gone down easily by playing West for the ♠Q.

Or you could have made it whoever held the ♠Q by using the "improved" plan.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 10 6 ♥ K 10 9 6 ♦ 8 7 5 ♣ A 6 2	
♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A Q 8 7 4 2 ♦ 6 ♣ K 7 5	N W E S	♠ K 8 7 3 ♥ 5 ♦ K Q 9 4 2 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ A Q 5 ♥ J 3 ♦ A J 10 3 ♣ Q J 10 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♥	Dbl		
All Pass			

2♥ by West
Lead: ♠J

Sometimes the opponents make overcalls which disrupt the smooth flow of your side's bidding. You and your partner need to have ways of dealing with these disruptions. One possibility is the **lebensohl** convention which is used a few times in these 100 Deals. There are lots of other methods out there, and you may not care for lebensohl. One of the big reasons we use it is that it includes a penalty double - some other methods use the double for other reasons.

So, in lebensohl an immediate double of their overcall of partner's 1NT opener is for penalties. Just like this one - punish them if they dare try to disrupt your bidding!

The contract is 2♥ doubled, played by West.

To see all the hands

West is to play 2♥ Doubled.

This is the only Deal like this out of the 100.

No Declarer Plan for you to make, no tricks to look for.

Just play through the deal as you think it might go and see how many tricks you can set West. Enjoy.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K Q J 8 ♥ K Q ♦ A 6 5 ♣ J 7 6 3	
♠ 10 7 4 2 ♥ A 5 4 3 ♦ J 4 ♣ 10 8 2		♠ 9 5 3 ♥ J 10 8 6 ♦ Q 9 7 2 ♣ 9 4
	♠ A 6 ♥ 9 7 2 ♦ K 10 8 3 ♣ A K Q 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	4NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♥J

Partner's 4NT bid is not Blackwood, it is the Quantitative 4NT. He is unsure whether to bid 6NT or not, so is inviting you to do so.

With 15 points you are supposed to pass. With 17 points you are supposed to bid 6NT. Wouldn't you know it, 16 points. Today you feel bold, so you say 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♥J.

West plays the ♥A and returns the ♥3.

Winner List: ♠ = 4 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

One trick is already lost and at first glance it looks like your only slim chance will be for the ♦ Q J to fall doubleton.

But a dummy has a very important card, the ♥9. You know from the opening lead that East holds the ♥10, so if he happens to hold the only guard in ♦s you will be able to squeeze him in the red suits.

You don't even have to do anything special. Play your 4 ♣ winners, then 3 ♠ winners.

Now play the ♠J and watch East's discard. If he throws the ♥10 dummy's ♥9 will become a winner. If he doesn't throw the ♥10 then you know dummy's ♥9 is worthless so discard it and hope the ♦s are good.

Squeeze plays can be complex to figure out and difficult to execute.

But not always. Sometimes they just happen, like this one. You were really hoping for the ♦Q and ♦J to fall and you fell into the squeeze instead.